



Cusp of history: India would be wise to learn from its past errors to give itself a chance to lift its first senior trophy — at home no less.

plagued the top order in its entirety and was a standout feature of the sole loss that India suffered in this series. Pratika (SR: 78.86) and Smriti (SR: 90.41) scoring at a sub-100 rate underline the value of someone as explosive as Shafali in the top three, which should keep Harleen on her toes as well. With the World Cup in mind, teams like Australia can capitalise on this aspect in key clashes.

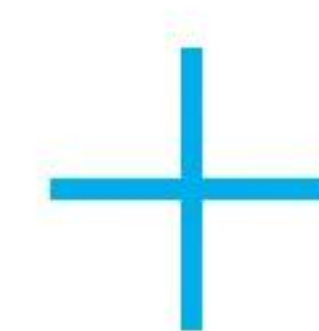
Off-spinner Sneha (**above, second from left**) returned to the ODI setup after more than a year and immediately got comfortable. A 15-wicket haul, which included a fiver against South Africa, helped her walk away with the Player of the Series award. She maximised her pace-off deliveries and worked on wide yorkers and seam variations in her armoury to finish the tour with an impressive average of 14.00 and an economy of 4.73. As positive as Sneha's return to the mix is for the team on one hand, the generous debuts handed out largely to up-and-coming bowlers isn't the positive one might think it to be.

Of the 17 debuts in 23 ODIs since December 2023, 10 are fast bowlers (all-rounders) and two are batters. A

part of this was mandated by injuries to the likes of Pooja Vastrakar, Renuka Singh Thakur, Asha Sobhana and Shreyanka Patil. While India having the depth to blood this much talent is an encouraging sign, the fact that the bowling still isn't set in stone barely five months away from the ODI World Cup is a fault line.

For all its experimentation, opportunities have not been consistent. Tejal Hasabnis made her entry to the setup during the New Zealand series in 2024, but hasn't been given a steady run. Minnu Mani is another casualty of the same tendency. The three debutants in this series — N. Sree Charani, Shuchi Upadhyay and Kashvee Gautam — all had rough initiations into the format, going for plenty of runs. Charani managed six wickets from the tour to Lanka and has impressed with her persistence and aggression.

However, the merry-go-round of bowling options brings more instability than otherwise, and India would be wise to learn from its errors in the T20 World Cup to give itself a chance to lift its first senior trophy — at home no less.



List of debutantes in ODIs for India since December 2023

Bowlers

Saika Ishaque, Arundhati Reddy, Mannat Kashyap, Asha Sobhana, Saima Thakor, Priya Mishra, Titas Sadhu, Minnu Mani, Sree Charani, Kranti Goud, Shreyanka Patil, Tanuja Kanwar, Sayali Sathgare, Kashvee Gautam, Shuchi Upadhyay

Batters

Pratika Rawal, Tejal Hasabnis